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A Lavish, Roman-Period Burial Cave in Tiberias

UZI LEIBNER¹ YAIR AMITZUR²

ABSTRACT: This article presents a lavish, Roman-period burial cave discovered in the northern necropolis of Tiberias. It consisted of three skillfully hewn rooms comprising a vestibule with wall paintings and two burial chambers with loculi. Two ossuaries were discovered in the cave, one bearing a Greek inscription. Another Greek inscription, originally placed above one of the loculi, apparently mentioned one of the family patriarchs. Pottery vessels and oil lamps found in the cave date its use to the late first and mainly to the second century CE. The cave's opulence, and the attestation of a population that was literate in Greek, indicate that it belonged to one of the elite Jewish families of Tiberias.

Keywords: Roman Galilee, Jewish burial customs, ossilegium, Greek inscription, Tiberias

A lavish, Roman-period burial cave with unique characteristics that distinguish it from similar caves of the same era was discovered during development work carried out in northern Tiberias, at a point overlooking the Sea of Galilee.¹ The cave is a valuable addition to our knowledge of burial practices in this region and period.

1 The cave was uncovered in 2018 during development work for the Mul Arbel neighborhood (map reference NIG 249800/745485). Pressure applied by the ultra-orthodox organization, Atra Kadisha, led to the sealing of the cave before it could be properly documented, thus the description in this article is based on a preliminary survey of the cave's interior and cleaning of its vestibule by Yair Amitzur. The cave was subsequently looted by antiquities robbers who inflicted heavy damage and stole its artefacts.

Our thanks to Leah Di Segni for deciphering the Greek inscriptions, Michael Peleg of the Israel Antiquities Authority for the photographs and preparation of the photogrammetric model of the cave, Ro'i Sabar for preparing the plan, the Computational Archaeology Laboratory at the Institute of Archaeology of The Hebrew University of Jerusalem for scanning the finds, Miriam Lavi and Aviya Elharar of the Conservation Laboratory of the Institute of Archaeology of the Hebrew University of Jerusalem for restoring the oil lamps, Silvia Rozenberg for her assistance with the wall paintings, and Boaz Zissu for his academic counsel.

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The cemeteries of Roman-Byzantine Tiberias extended both towards Hammat Tiberias to the south and along the routes leading north and northwest of the city. The cave under discussion is located above, i.e., west of the route leading north towards Magdala, south of Tel Raqqat (Khirbet el-Quneitra) (fig. 1). It is c. two kilometers from the built-up area of Roman Tiberias and c. one kilometer from the burials and mausolea known in this area. The basaltic bedrock



Fig. 1. Location map of the burial cave (star) and built mausolea (dots) in the northern necropolis of Tiberias

in Tiberias precluded the quarrying of burial caves in its environs. Thus, the hundreds of Roman-Byzantine graves discovered to date are mainly cist tombs, sarcophagi interred in the ground or placed upon it, or mausolea (Betzer 2013; 2021). Remains of nine mausolea are known from the northern necropolis, usually with loculi (*kokhim*) built instead of hewn, as is generally found in burial caves (Stepansky 1999; Vitto 2008). The location for the burial cave under discussion was apparently chosen due to the limestone outcrop in which it is situated, which enabled quarrying.

The cave was severely damaged by the development work, and concrete was poured into its inner room. It was not excavated, and the following

description is based on a survey and documentation performed before it was sealed (see note 1).

THE PLAN AND DECORATION

The cave consisted of three skillfully hewn rooms along an east–west axis, comprising a vestibule and two burial chambers with loculi (fig. 2).

The Vestibule

Although the first room was mostly destroyed, it was clearly a vestibule with entirely rock-hewn floor, roof, and walls. It was c. 5.0 m wide, with the walls standing over 2.0 m high; its original length is unknown. Two layers of plaster coating the vestibule's walls were revealed, and the remnants show that its floor was similarly plastered. The lower wall plaster layer was adorned with paintings, executed in the *secco* technique (painting on dry plaster) and included geometric patterns in shades of red, yellow, green, white, and black. The colours on the

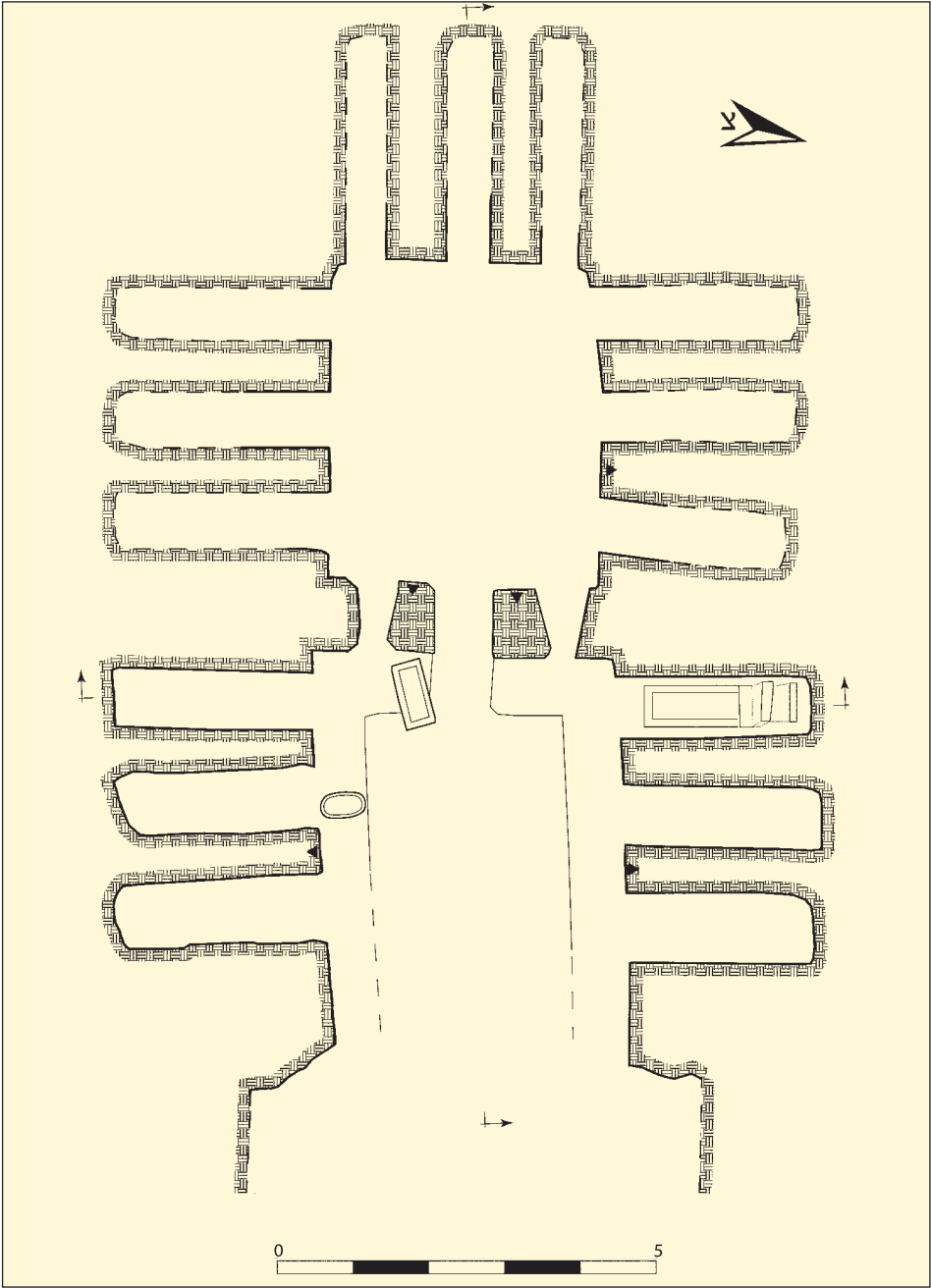


Fig. 2. Plan of the burial cave

surviving sections were remarkably well preserved, owing most likely to the second, subsequent plaster overlay (see below). A full-length section that survived in the southwestern corner of the vestibule enables partial reconstruction of the ornamental patterns (fig. 3).

The vestibule was decorated with the typical wall division into a high socle, an orthostat central zone, and an upper, lighter-coloured area, common in the Roman world from the late first century CE onwards. The paint seems to have been applied in broad, roughly executed stretches, and the general colour scheme was very simple. The walls were decorated in a limited range of colours, including purple-red or black for the socle, red, black, or green for the large panels, white



Fig. 3. Wall paintings in the southwestern corner of the vestibule; note remains of the plastered floor

and green for the frames and string courses, and white or yellow for the upper part of the wall. The details of execution show similarities with wall paintings from the second century CE.²

The better-preserved southern wall included a poorly preserved socle (0.25 m high), originally red but now primarily gray, topped by a white and green string course (each band 5 cm wide). The orthostat section in the middle included a large, vertical, rectangular, red panel (1.20 m high) with an upper, white-green horizontal border (5 cm wide). Inside, remains of white lines framing the inner panel decoration were discernible. Above the white-green border was a black panel (0.20 m high) with red borders on either side, probably part of an isodomic row. The upper portion of the wall on top of the black area included a white band (5 cm wide) topped by a black and red horizontal schematic garland which indicated the beginning of the higher, yellow area (c. 0.35 m high). The western wall was apparently similarly decorated, perhaps with a green panel and some kind of alabaster imitation for the lower socle (35 cm) that was decorated with a green, red, and pink undulating pattern on a white background.

A layer of white plaster was found superimposed over the *secco* layer; grooves were incised in the painting to provide a better grip for the new layer. Possibly, during a refurbishment of the cave, the renovators opted, for whatever reason, to conceal the paintings under white plaster.

A stylized opening built of skillfully worked basalt stones was constructed in the vestibule's hewn western wall. Although this opening was destroyed during the modern development work, its collapsed fragments were found *in situ* in their entirety (fig. 4). They included a threshold with a socket for the door pivot, a pair of monolithic ashlar doorjambes, and a heavy stone door with stone pivots and a thru-hole through which a hand could be inserted to reach the locking device fitted in a recessed groove on the inner side of the door.



Fig. 4. The vestibule at the beginning of cleaning, looking west; note the wall paintings in the corner on the right and the collapsed fragments of the basalt doorway in the center

The Central Room

The central room was a burial chamber, entirely rock-hewn and measuring roughly 5.0 x 4.0 m. It was surrounded

2 See, e.g., the wall paintings in the villa of Sette Bassi in Rome (Fogagnolo 2016: fig. 8), in the apse of the Villa di Augusto (Somma Vesuviana) in Naples (Aoyagi and Angelelli 2013: fig. 19), and in the Maison du Trompe l'oeil in Zeugma, Turkey (Barbet 2005: pl. XXXVI.1).

by stone shelves, 0.40 m high (fig. 5). Behind and above the shelves, three loculi were hewn in the northern wall and three in the southern wall, each measuring c. 2.0 m in length. Large triangular-shaped niches for oil lamps were hewn into the northern and southern walls above the loculi. The last loculus in the northern wall contained a hewn burial trench. A recessed frame in its upper part supported a cover of well-fitted stone slabs. A shallow, rectangular niche carved above this loculus contained a limestone slab with a *tabula ansata* relief bearing a Greek inscription that apparently mentioned the family's father (see below).



Fig. 5. The central burial chamber, looking west to the opening of the inner chamber

Near this loculus, an opening leading to an additional inner burial chamber was hewn in the middle of the chamber's western wall. Since the grave of the family patriarch is sometimes known to face the cave entrance, it is possible that this was the original burial from which his bones were evacuated to the neighboring loculus when the need to hew an additional burial chamber arose. This is supported by the opening's shape, which resembles that of the burial loculi, its upper part containing the remnants of a frame for a sealing stone.³

3 For the characteristics of *paterfamilias* burials in Jewish burial caves of the Early Roman period, see Abadi-Reiss 2019.

Apparently, breaking through to create the entrance to the inner chamber required dismantling the lower portion of the frame and the shelf in front of the loculus. Flanking the opening and above the surrounding shelves were windows open to the inner chamber. The southern window also had a frame for a sealing stone, suggesting that initially these were niches used as bone repositories or loculi for child burials that were converted into windows when the cave was expanded.

The inner burial chamber was on a lower level that was probably accessed by one or two steps (fig. 6); its dimensions resembled those of the central chamber. It contained nine hewn loculi, three in the northern wall, three in the southern wall, and three in the western wall, facing the entrance. Its ceiling was arched and lower than the straight ceiling of the central chamber. Large triangular niches for oil lamps were carved near the ceiling, flanking the opening and in the northern wall. The chamber was partially covered by concrete poured into it during the modern development work; thus, some of its characteristics were obscured.



Fig. 6. Photogrammetric model of the cave, looking south

The Finds: Ossuaries, Pottery, Lamps, and Glass

The finds were recovered mainly from the vestibule's floor, with a few in the central chamber and on the slope below the vestibule to the east. As no other remains were found in the area, all the items are clearly from the cave. The cave was not excavated and was possibly plundered in the past. Therefore, the following description probably comprises an incomplete inventory. The survey did not reveal any skeletal remains.

Two ossuaries were found on the southern shelf of the central chamber (see fig. 2). However, their original position is unknown since the cave had been

disturbed. The first was made of limestone, lacked feet, and had a ledge for a sliding lid (fig. 7).⁴ It was carefully fashioned with a fine-toothed chisel. One of its long sides bore a Greek inscription (see below). The second ossuary, found nearby, was made of ceramic and was oval-shaped, resembling a small bathtub. On top of both its long sides was a decorative relief consisting of a circle from which two horns protruded, perhaps simulating rounded handles or rudimentary wreaths (fig. 8).⁵



Fig. 7. The limestone ossuary



Fig. 8. The ceramic ossuary

Sherds of pottery vessels, two oil lamps, and the base of a glass vessel were recovered from the cave (fig. 9). Most of the vessels were of types typically found in Roman Galilee, from the workshops at Kefar Ḥananya and Shiḥin (Adan-Bayewitz 1993).

About two-thirds of the fragmentary vessels found in the cave were characteristic of assemblages from the Middle Roman period, i.e., the second to mid-third centuries CE. That said, the rounded casseroles (fig. 9, nos. 1–2) and the closed cooking pots with a grooved rim (fig. 9, nos. 3–4) were typical of Early Roman assemblages from around the mid-first century BCE onwards. These two types were absent from the rich assemblages of the early second century CE destruction layer uncovered at nearby Khirbet Wadi Ḥamam. The latter assemblages contained casseroles with a sharp carination at the shoulder (cf. fig. 9, no. 7) and closed cooking pots with two accentuated grooves on the rim and a shallow groove on the shoulder (cf. fig. 9, no. 9), which were characteristic of the Middle Roman period. Therefore, both of the abovementioned Early Roman types were prevalent in assemblages only up to around the end of the first century CE.⁶ The presence of the two kraters (fig. 9, nos. 5–6), one of them restorable, is

4 For this type of ossuary, see Rahmani 1994: 5, fig. 2.

5 Similar decorations on lead coffins were interpreted as wreaths, e.g., Rahmani 1999: Pl. 25: Cat. nos. 49–50.

6 For a discussion on the transition from Early Roman to Middle Roman pottery assemblages in Galilee, see Leibner 2018: 319–322.

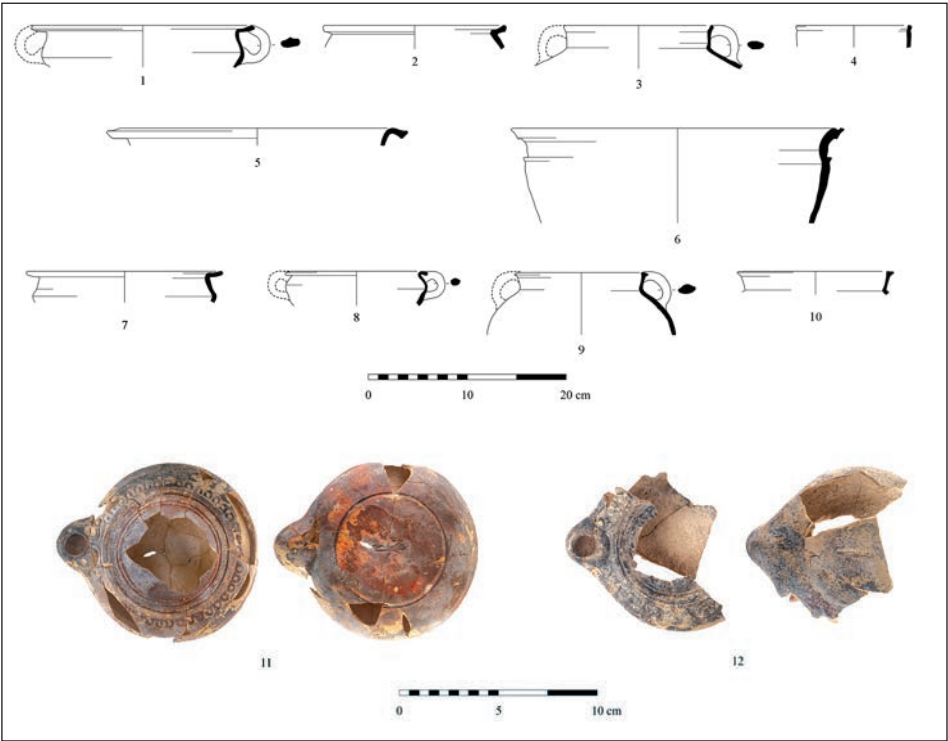


Fig. 9. Pottery vessels and oil lamps from the burial cave

No.	Location	Description and Type	Parallels
1	Vestibule	Early Roman globular casserole with broad ledged rim; type KH3a*	Adan-Bayewitz 1993: 111–119; Berlin 2006: 41, Figs. 2.16, 2.18; Loffreda 2008: 198–199 (Tipo TEG 12); Balouka 2013: 27, Pls. 1:5, 2:14–19, 9:1–6
2	Front slope	Same as No. 1	
3	Vestibule	Early Roman closed cooking pot with groove on inner rim; type KH4a	Adan-Bayewitz 1993: 124–125; Berlin 2006: 32, Fig. 2.14; Loffreda 2008: 178–179 (Tipo PENT 10); Balouka 2013: 21, Pls. 2:1–13; 8:1–3
4	Vestibule	Same as No. 3	
5	Vestibule	Middle Roman large krater, usually with a broad rim terminating upward ('Sepphoris bowl')	Loffreda 2008: 223–224 (Tipo PIAT 22a); Balouka 2013: 46–47, Pl. 12.1–8
6	Vestibule	Same as No. 5	
7	Vestibule	Middle Roman casserole with sharp shoulder carination and flat, horizontal ledged rim; type KH3b	Adan-Bayewitz 1993: 119–124; Loffreda 2008: 199–200 (Tipo TEG 13); Balouka 2013: 28 (OCP1b), Pl. 13:6–9

8	Vestibule	Middle Roman small casserole with down-turned ledge rim	Balouka 2013: 26, Pl. 15:5–11
9	Vestibule	Middle Roman globular closed cooking pot with two grooves on rim and shallow groove on shoulder; type KH4b/c (transitional form)	Adan-Bayewitz 1993: 126; Leibner 2018: 310, Fig. 9.15
10	Vestibule	Middle Roman globular closed cooking pot with two shallow grooves on rim; type KH4c	Adan-Bayewitz 1993: 128–130; Loffreda 2008: 182 (Tipo PENT 13); Balouka 2013: 22 (CP3b), Pl. 13:1–5
11	Vestibule	Roman Discus Lamp (Broneer type XXV) with round body, thin walls, sunken discus, and small, round nozzle decorated with semi-volutes on its sides; ovolo pattern on shoulders; manufacturer's mark on base; brown-red slip	Broneer 1930: 83–87, 182–184, Pl. X, Nos. 505–525; Hadad 2002: 16, Nos. 19–24 (type 7, Variant 1, cf. base of No. 19); Rosenthal-Heginbottom 2011: 195–202, Nos. 1–29; Sussman 2012: 55–68, Figs. 44–52, Nos. 254–689
12	Vestibule	Same as No. 11; dark-brown slip	

*KH-Kefar Hananya (Adan-Bayewitz 1993)

also notable, as vessels of this type were rarely found in Galilean burial caves.

The Roman discus lamps (fig. 9, nos. 11–12) were of local Syro-Palestinian types found in the region from approximately the last third of the first century CE. They were prevalent mainly in assemblages of the second century CE (other, cruder types were present until the early third century). Based on their relatively large dimensions, thin walls, ornamental style, and fine execution, the two examples from the cave can be dated approximately to the final decades of the first century through the mid-second century CE (cf. Vitto 2011: 51*). Although the lamps underwent restoration, not all fragments of their discs were recovered, and it seems they were deliberately broken in antiquity. Many such lamps are known to have intentionally broken discs. Several hypotheses were broached to explain this practice. It might have been connected to a specific ethnic group, e.g., a custom relating to the observance of ritual purity (Brand 1953: 350–353), or served as a religious or self-defining act of eschewing figurative or pagan motifs (Tal and Teixeira-Bastos 2012). It could also have been intended to enlarge the lamps' typically minute filling holes (Lapp 2016: 49).

The assemblage indicates activity in the cave from the Early Roman period, apparently only from the last decades of the first century CE, given the relative dearth of finds from this period. The main period of activity was most likely the second century CE, and the cave was possibly still in use through the early third century.

The Inscriptions

The burial cave contained two Greek inscriptions. The first, carefully engraved on the wall of the limestone ossuary and painted in red, had large letters that read ΤΥΡΑΝΝΙΔΟΣ, (of) Tyrannis, a female name hitherto not attested in the corpus of names from Palestine, but known in inscriptions from Greece, Asia Minor, and Rome (e.g., Pleket and Stroud 1990: nos. 170, 487) (fig. 10). The feminine



Fig. 10. The inscription on the limestone ossuary



Fig. 11. The inscribed limestone slab above the northwestern loculus in the central burial chamber

noun, tyrannis, meaning monarchy or sovereignty, was also used in the sense of ‘princess,’ as in the Septuagint for Esther (Esther 1:18, שְׂרוּת פֶּרֶס וּמְדִי). We may therefore suggest this was a sophisticated, Hellenized form of the Hebrew name Sara.⁷ Paleographically, the inscription appears to be from the first or second century CE.

The second inscription was found above one burial loculi, shallowly inscribed on a limestone slab. The left part of the slab was broken, and the surviving part bore the words ---ΜΟΥ ΠΑΤΡΟΣ (fig. 11). The first word, in larger script, was only partially preserved (---ΜΟΥ) and was the genitive ending of a name ending in -ΜΟΣ. It may be one of many Greek or Latin names, like Philodemos or Decimus, or a Hebrew name in Greek transcription, e.g., Nahum = Ναουμος, or Abraham = Αβρααμος. Since the tomb under discussion was a Jewish burial, the second option seems more likely. A Greek inscription from a

nearby mausoleum included Hebrew and Aramaic names in Greek transactions: Joseph, Elazar, and Shila (Damati 1999; Stepansky 1999).

The second word in the second inscription was *patros*, meaning father, also in the genitive, i.e., ‘the (tomb) of [so and so], our father.’ Seemingly then, this was the burial of one of the patriarchs of the family, interred here by his descendants. This inscription was clearly not engraved by a professional craftsman. Instead, it

7 We thank Leah Di Segni for this observation.

was likely inscribed by a family member of the deceased, indicating a population with Greek literacy.

DISCUSSION

Only a handful of loculi caves with a double burial chamber have hitherto been uncovered in Galilee, including Gush Halav (Makhoully 1939) and Meroth (Ilan and Damati 1987: 162–163). Rarer still were loculi caves ornamented, even partially, with frescoes. One such cave was uncovered at Ḥanita (Barag 1978), and another, containing both loculi and *arcosolia*, was found at Khirbet el-Ḥamsin, east of Akhziv (Frankel and Getzov 1997: Site 134). Both of these belonged to the Phoenician realm of material culture in western Galilee. A lavish burial cave with a frescoed vestibule was uncovered at Ḥorvat Midras in the Judean lowlands (Kloner 1978: 117), and another, with a burial chamber adorned by frescoes, was discovered in Jericho (Hachlili 1985). The last two were Jewish burial caves from the late Second Temple period, from which ossuaries were also recovered.

It has been argued that secondary burial in ossuaries first appeared in Galilee after the destruction of the Second Temple, or even as late as the post-Bar Kokhba period, i.e., a century or more later than it emerged in Jerusalem. It was suggested that this custom had been introduced in the region by refugees arriving from Judea (Aviam and Syon 2002). This view was based on the fact that ossuaries were discovered in Galilean caves containing either mixed finds from the first and second centuries CE or only from the second century onwards. In contrast, none were discovered in caves with finds exclusively from the first century CE. This, obviously, is not a decisive conclusion since it is impossible to determine that the ossuaries in the caves with mixed finds were used specifically during the later burial stages. It also bears noting that due to the continuity of settlement, almost no burial caves dating solely to the first century CE have been discovered in Galilee. In our case, too, it is impossible to unequivocally determine if ossilegium was practiced in the first century CE when burial in the cave first began, or rather in the second century, which was apparently the main period of use. The internal burial chamber was likely added at a second stage, possibly when the vestibule's wall paintings were overlaid with white plaster. In any case, since the cave apparently served as the burial site of a local family for several generations from the first century CE onwards, it is unlikely that these were Judean refugees.

Presumably, the limestone outcrop and the proximity to the main road that passed below were determining factors in selecting the location for this unique burial cave, as was, plausibly, the splendid view it commanded. Indeed, there may be other, as yet undiscovered caves nearby. The cave's dimensions and the extraordinary quality of its hewing and ornamentation are instructive of its owners' economic means, while the secondary burial in ossuaries demonstrates that they were Jewish. As far as we know, Tiberias at this time was predominantly

Jewish, a point reinforcing the ethnic identification of the cave's owners. Together with the proximity to the northern necropolis of Tiberias, and in light of the inscriptions pointing to a population that was literate in Greek, it is reasonable to conclude that this was one of the elite families of Tiberias since the primary language used in the surrounding rural sector during this period was Aramaic and probably also Hebrew (Fassberg 2012).

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